

Halgiric Research Integration Series

BLACKFOOT CONFEDERACY

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Siksika, Kainai, and Piikani — Sacred Traditions of the Northern Plains

The Siksika, Kainai, and Piikani moved as one people
across the northern Great Plains and the foothills of the Rockies —
the Lords of the Plains, keepers of the sacred bundles,
people of the Sun Dance, the vision quest, and the medicine pipe.
Napi shaped the world. Apistotoke breathed life into it.
The Blackfoot are still here.

Contents

A Note on Sacred Knowledge and This Document.....	3
Introduction — The People of the Northern Plains.....	3
The Three Nations — Siksika, Kainai, and Piikani.....	3
Language, Territory, and Confederacy.....	3
The Blackfoot Cosmos — Structure of the Sacred Universe.....	4
Napi — The Creator-Trickster.....	4
The Sun (Naatos) and Moon (Kokomikeis).....	4
Above Persons, Ground Persons, and Under Water Persons.....	5
The Sacred Role of the Buffalo (Innii).....	5
Medicine Bundles — Living Sacred Objects.....	5
The Thunder Medicine Pipe Bundle.....	5
The Beaver Bundle.....	6
The Medicine Pipe Ceremony — Step-by-Step.....	6
The Okan — Sundance, The Most Sacred Ceremony.....	7
Sundance Preparation — What Happens Before.....	7
The Sundance Ceremony — Day-by-Day Structure.....	7
The Ikunuhkahtsi — Age-Graded Societies and Social Structure.....	8
The Horn Society and Sacred Societies.....	8
Names as Sacred Property — Birth and the Blackfoot Naming Tradition.....	8
The Vision Quest — Going to Seek Power.....	8
The Vision Quest — Step-by-Step.....	9
Sweat Lodge (Motokiks) — The Foundational Purification Practice.....	9
Sweat Lodge — Step-by-Step.....	9
Iniskim — The Buffalo Calling Stone.....	10
Sacred Herbs — Sweetgrass, Sage, and Cedar.....	10
Death, Mourning, and the Journey to the Sand Hills.....	10
The Transfer Ceremony (Isskinikssiyi).....	11
Blackfoot Astronomy and the Sacred Calendar.....	11
Contemporary Blackfoot — Repatriation and Living Tradition.....	11
Blackfoot Sacred Wellness -- Nitsitapiisinni and the Medicine Bundle.....	12
The Haligricity Lens — Bundle, Transfer, and Living Sacred Objects.....	13

A Note on Sacred Knowledge and This Document

Blackfoot sacred tradition carries layers of knowledge — some of which has been shared publicly through academic collaboration with Blackfoot community members, some of which exists in the published ethnographic record, and some of which is intentionally protected within the community as knowledge that requires specific initiation, bundle ownership, or community standing to properly hold and transmit. This guide draws on the extensive ethnographic record — particularly the work of Clark Wissler, Walter McClintock, Adolf Hungry Wolf, and the collaborative scholarship produced with Blackfoot community input — while acknowledging that the most sacred dimensions of bundle ceremony, vision experience, and transfer knowledge belong to their community keepers.

Introduction — The People of the Northern Plains

The Blackfoot Confederacy — comprising the Siksika (Blackfoot proper), Kainai (Blood), and Piikani (Peigan, divided since the 1870s into the Apatohsippiikani/Northern Peigan in Canada and the Aamsskáápipikani/Southern Peigan or Blackfeet in Montana) — represents one of the most powerful, most culturally distinct, and most spiritually sophisticated Indigenous nations of the North American plains. At their height in the 18th and early 19th centuries, the Blackfoot Confederacy dominated a territory of approximately 300,000 square miles stretching from the North Saskatchewan River in present-day Alberta south into Montana — a territory defined not by fixed borders but by the seasonal movement of the Buffalo (Iinnii) and the Confederacy's ability to defend it.

The Blackfoot are Niitsitapi — the Real People. Their sacred tradition is among the most completely documented Plains traditions in the ethnographic record, with detailed accounts of bundle ceremonies, the Okan (Sundance), the vision quest, and the transfer ceremony going back to the early 20th century. Their tradition is also very much alive — the Okan is still held every summer, bundles are still transferred, and the language (Niitsipii-tai'i, Blackfoot) is still spoken.

The Three Nations — Siksika, Kainai, and Piikani

SIKSIKA (BLACKFOOT PROPER)

The northernmost nation of the Confederacy — their name means 'Black Foot People,' traditionally understood as referring to the blackened moccasins worn by those who walked through prairie fires or who blackened their moccasins with paint. The Siksika occupy the territory around the Bow River in present-day southern Alberta. Their reserve is located near Gleichen, Alberta.

KAINAI (BLOOD NATION)

The largest of the three nations by population — their name (Kainai, 'Many Chiefs') reflects their political structure, in which numerous bands were led by numerous recognized leaders. The Kainai occupy territory in southern Alberta around the Oldman River and its tributaries. Their reserve, the Blood Reserve (also known as Kainai Nation), is the largest First Nations reserve in Canada by land area.

PIIKANI (PEIGAN / PEIGAN)

The southernmost and most dispersed of the three nations — divided since the reserve period of the 1870s-1880s into the Northern Peigan (Apatohsippiikani, now Piikani Nation in Alberta) and the Southern Peigan (Aamsskáápipikani, now the Blackfeet Nation in Montana). The Piikani occupied the territory along the Rocky Mountain foothills, giving them particular access to specific sacred sites in the mountains.

Language, Territory, and Confederacy

The Blackfoot language (Niitsipii-tai'i — 'Real Speak') is a member of the Algonquian language family — making the Blackfoot linguistically related to the Cree, Ojibwe, and other Algonquian speakers of North America, despite being culturally and geographically a Plains people. The language is polysynthetic (encoding complex meaning in single words through suffixes and prefixes) and deeply tied to the sacred tradition — the specific words for prayers, ceremonies, and sacred beings are irreplaceable.

The three nations of the Confederacy have been allied for at least several centuries — sharing language (dialectal variations of Blackfoot/Niitsitapi), sacred traditions, ceremony, and mutual defense. Despite their confederacy, each

nation maintains its own political identity, its own band structure, and its own distinctive sacred practices within the shared framework.

The Blackfoot Cosmos — Structure of the Sacred Universe

The Blackfoot universe is organized into three interpenetrating realms — not separate levels stacked vertically (like some traditions) but three dimensions of the same world that are always simultaneously present and always in relationship with each other.

THE ABOVE WORLD (ABOVE PERSONS — SPOMMITAPIIKSI)

The sky world — home of the Sun (Naatos), Moon (Kokomikeis), Morning Star (Ipiso'waahss), and the Thunder Beings. The Above Persons are the most powerful sacred beings in the Blackfoot cosmos, and their relationship with the Blackfoot people is covenantal — they give specific gifts and require specific ceremonial obligations in return.

THE EARTH WORLD (GROUND PERSONS — KSAAHKOMIITAPIIKSI)

The visible world of human beings, animals, plants, and landscape — but also the home of sacred beings who inhabit specific earth locations (specific mountains, caves, and geological features). Sacred animals (Buffalo, Bear, Eagle) are understood as Ground Persons with their own sacred authority.

THE UNDER WATER WORLD (UNDER WATER PERSONS — SOYIINITAPIIKSI)

The underwater realm — home of the Under Water Persons, beings of great power associated with specific lakes and rivers throughout Blackfoot territory. The Beaver Bundle's origin story involves an encounter with an Under Water Person. Lakes and rivers are understood as thresholds where underwater beings may be encountered.

Napi — The Creator-Trickster

Napi (Old Man) is the most important and most complex figure in Blackfoot sacred narrative — simultaneously creator, culture hero, and trickster. He is not God in the Abrahamic sense (that function belongs more properly to the Sun, Naatos, and to Apistotoke — the Source of Life above the Sun) but the immediate creator of the physical world as it exists — including its imperfections — and the one who gave human beings their specific forms and specific capacities.

Napi made the world from mud and water. He shaped the animals and human beings from clay. He gave them their specific forms and their specific relationships. But his creation is always imperfect, always open to revision, always marked by his own character — because Napi is simultaneously the creator and the trickster, and his world reflects both roles.

Napi is also the world's great trickster — lustful, greedy, foolish, and endlessly self-deceiving in the story traditions. He is tricked by animals, bamboozled by rocks, outwitted by Coyote, and generally demonstrates every human failing with exaggerated clarity. This trickster dimension is not separate from the creator dimension — they are the same being. The Blackfoot narrative tradition uses Napi's failures as instruction: here is what happens when you are greedy; here is what happens when you lie; here is what happens when you disrespect the sacred.

Old Woman negotiated with Napi over the nature of the world they were creating together. 'I will make everything,' Napi declared. Old Woman said, 'You will make the decisions, but I will review them.' Their dialogue produces some of the world's most important features, including death: Old Man wanted people to live forever; Old Woman said, 'No — if they lived forever, the earth would become too crowded and people would not appreciate their time here.' The dialogue between Napi and Old Woman encodes the Blackfoot understanding of the world as the product of creative negotiation, not unilateral divine decree.

The Sun (Naatos) and Moon (Kokomikeis)

Naatos (the Sun) is the most powerful and most widely honored of the Above People — the being who governs light, life, growth, and the cosmic order. The relationship between the Blackfoot people and the Sun is not merely devotional; it is covenantal — the Sun makes specific demands (the Sundance/Okan is the primary expression of this covenant) and provides specific gifts in return. The Sun's most important gift to the Blackfoot was the Sundance itself — transmitted through the Feather Woman story.

THE FEATHER WOMAN STORY: A young woman (Soatsaki, Feather Woman) fell in love with Morning Star, who appeared to her and took her to live in the sky world with him and his parents, the Sun and Moon. She bore a son, Poia (Scarface). She was told never to dig the large turnip near the Sun's tipi — but curiosity overcame her, and when she dug it, she saw through the hole to the earth below. Overcome with homesickness, she was sent back. She brought with her the specific sacred knowledge of the Okan ceremony, which the Sun had given to Morning Star to give to the people. This is how the Sundance came to the Blackfoot — as a gift from the Sun, transmitted through a woman's love and loss.

Kokomikeis (the Moon) is the Sun's wife and Morning Star's mother. She is the grandmother of the people — the specific source of warmth and comfort, the protector of women's ceremonies. The Natoas Bundle (the sacred bundle of the Okan) is specifically connected to the Moon as well as the Sun.

Above Persons, Ground Persons, and Under Water Persons

The Blackfoot sacred world is populated by a rich ecology of sacred beings beyond the primary figures of Napi and the Sun. Each category of being governs specific domains and can be approached through specific ceremonial protocols.

The Thunder Beings (Ksiistsikomm) are the most powerful and most feared of the Above Persons — the source of thunder, lightning, and the spring rains. The Thunder Medicine Pipe Bundles are specifically connected to the Thunder Beings; their awakening ceremony in spring (at the first thunder) is one of the most important ceremonial moments of the Blackfoot year.

Sacred animals occupy a unique position — they are simultaneously Ground Persons with their own sacred authority and intermediaries between the human world and the broader sacred world. Buffalo, Bear, Eagle, and Beaver are the most sacred, each with specific bundle associations and specific ceremonial protocols. The Under Water Persons hold particular significance for the Beaver Bundle, since the Bundle's origin story involves a being from beneath the water granting its contents to the first keeper.

The Sacred Role of the Buffalo (Iinnii)

The Buffalo (Iinnii — also written Iinii) is not merely a food source for the Blackfoot — it is the sacred being whose relationship with the Blackfoot people constitutes the fundamental sacred covenant of Blackfoot life. The Buffalo gave the Blackfoot everything: food, clothing, shelter, tools, sacred medicines, and the specific sacred objects that anchor the most important ceremonies.

THE BUFFALO AS SACRED GIFT

In Blackfoot sacred narrative, the Buffalo chose to give themselves to the people — the relationship is not one of predation but of sacred exchange. The Buffalo spirit (the spiritual essence of the species, not individual animals) made a covenant with the Blackfoot people: the people would treat the Buffalo with proper respect (using everything, offering prayers and gratitude) and the Buffalo would continue to give themselves to sustain the people.

The near-extinction of the Buffalo in the 1870s-1880s — driven by commercial hide hunting and the deliberate US and Canadian government policy of destroying the food base of the Plains peoples — was not merely an ecological catastrophe but a sacred one: the breaking of the foundational covenant of Blackfoot life. The Iniskim (Buffalo Calling Stone) ceremonies and the Bundle system hold the ceremonial memory of the Buffalo relationship even in their physical absence.

Medicine Bundles — Living Sacred Objects

Medicine Bundles (Natoas — the term varies by specific bundle type) are the most distinctive and most sacred objects in Blackfoot material culture — wrapped collections of sacred items (animal skins, feathers, stones, plant medicines, sacred objects) each with its own origin story, its own spirit owner, its own specific ceremonies, and its own relationship with the living world.

THE LIVING BUNDLE

The Blackfoot understanding of a Medicine Bundle as alive is not metaphorical. A Bundle has its own spirit, its own personality, its own needs and preferences. It must be fed (offerings placed near it), kept in specific conditions (wrapped in specific ways, housed in specific positions in the tipi), opened at specific times (not whenever the owner wishes, but

when the Bundle's own ceremonial calendar requires), and treated with the specific protocols established in its origin story.

ORIGIN, CUSTODY, AND TRANSFER

Each Bundle has a specific origin story in which the Bundle's constituent objects were given to a person by a sacred being — a spirit animal, a sky being, an underwater being — along with the specific songs, prayers, and protocols for the Bundle's use. This origin narrative is an essential part of the Bundle's sacred power. Bundles are owned by specific individuals — but ownership means custodianship, not possession in the ordinary sense. The Bundle continues to belong, in a deeper sense, to the sacred being who gave it.

The Thunder Medicine Pipe Bundle

The Thunder Medicine Pipe Bundles (Motoki or Ninaimsskaan — Thunder Pipe) are among the most sacred objects in Blackfoot tradition — pipe bundles whose spirit is directly connected to the Thunder Being (Ksiistsikomm), and whose ceremonial cycle is governed by thunder itself. The Thunder Medicine Pipe Bundles sleep through the winter — stored and not opened — and awaken each spring with the first thunder.

THE THUNDER PIPE CEREMONY — STEP-BY-STEP

THE AWAKENING (SPRING): The Thunder Medicine Pipe Bundle is formally unwrapped and opened for the first time each year in response to the first thunder of spring.

STEP 1 — THE HEARING OF THUNDER: When the first thunder of spring is heard, the Bundle owner performs specific immediate protocols — acknowledging the Thunder's return and beginning the process of opening the Bundle.

STEP 2 — THE GATHERING: The ceremony requires specific participants — the Bundle owner, their spouse, and invited sacred practitioners who know the specific songs and protocols.

STEP 3 — THE SWEAT LODGE (PURIFICATION): Before the main ceremony, a purification sweat lodge ceremony is conducted — preparing the participants to be in proper sacred relationship with the Thunder Medicine Pipe.

STEP 4 — THE OPENING OF THE BUNDLE: The Bundle is opened with specific songs and prayers — each wrapping layer removed according to specific protocol, with specific songs for each layer.

STEP 5 — THE PIPE IS SMOKED: The Thunder Medicine Pipe is formally smoked — the smoke carrying prayers to the Thunder Being and renewing the relationship.

STEP 6 — THE SONGS: Each item in the Bundle has its own specific song — the songs are sung in specific order, the sacred relationship of each object renewed through its song.

The Beaver Bundle

The Beaver Bundle (Ksikstaki Natoas) is generally considered the most ancient and most comprehensive of all Blackfoot sacred bundles — a massive collection of animal skins, plants, and sacred objects that constitutes a complete sacred encyclopedia of Blackfoot botanical and zoological knowledge, and whose ceremonies encompass a complete year-round ceremonial cycle.

THE PHYSICAL CONTENTS: The Beaver Bundle is massive — it contains the skins of numerous animals (beaver, otter, mink, weasel, and many others), plant medicines, and sacred objects, all wrapped in specific order with specific protocols for their arrangement. Each animal in the Bundle has its own specific song and its own specific sacred role.

THE BOTANICAL KNOWLEDGE: The Beaver Bundle is the primary repository of Blackfoot botanical and zoological sacred knowledge — the specific plants for specific healing purposes, the specific songs for calling specific species, the specific relationships between particular animals and particular sacred conditions. The Beaver Bundle ceremony is a comprehensive recitation of Blackfoot knowledge about the living world.

The Medicine Pipe Ceremony — Step-by-Step

STEP 1 — THE DECISION: The Bundle owner and their spouse decide to hold the ceremony at the ceremonially appropriate time.

STEP 2 — INVITATIONS: Specific practitioners who know the Bundle's songs and protocols are invited.

STEP 3 — PURIFICATION: All participants undergo sweat lodge purification before the ceremony begins.

STEP 4 — THE OPENING: The Bundle is opened according to its specific protocol — each layer removed with its specific song.

STEP 5 — THE DISPLAY: The Bundle's contents are arranged in their proper positions — the visual arrangement itself is ceremonial, each object placed according to its sacred relationship to the others.

STEP 6 — THE SONGS: Each object's song is sung — the Bundle's complete ceremonial content performed.

STEP 7 — THE CLOSING: The Bundle is wrapped according to its specific protocol and returned to its ceremonial position.

The Okan — Sundance, The Most Sacred Ceremony

The Okan (sometimes written Okaan — the Sundance in English, though this English name is an outsider's description rather than a Blackfoot term) is the most important ceremony of the Blackfoot sacred year — the great summer ceremony in which the entire Confederacy gathers, in which sacred vows made to the Sun throughout the preceding year are fulfilled, and in which the foundational covenant between the Blackfoot people and the Above People (particularly the Sun) is renewed.

THE RENEWAL OF COVENANT: The Okan is the Blackfoot people's primary annual act of sacred covenant renewal — the ceremony through which the relationship between the people and the Sun (established in the Feather Woman narrative) is affirmed, the people's gratitude for the Sun's gifts is expressed, and the Sun's continued blessings are sought for the coming year.

HEALING: The Okan is the most powerful healing ceremony in the Blackfoot tradition. People make vows to the Sun during times of crisis — 'If this person recovers, I will sponsor or participate in the Okan' — and the fulfillment of these vows at the Okan carries specific healing power. The dancing, the fasting, and the specific sacred rites of the Okan are understood as the fulfillment of obligations made in moments of need.

Sundance Preparation — What Happens Before

THE NATOAS WOMAN'S PREPARATION (MONTHS BEFORE): The woman who has vowed to sponsor the Okan begins specific preparation months in advance. She must be a woman of demonstrated virtue — her character is publicly known and publicly acknowledged, and in earlier times there was a public declaration of her worthiness.

THE GATHERING OF MATERIALS: Specific materials — the Natoas Bundle, the sacred center pole tree, specific offerings — are identified and prepared during the weeks before the ceremony.

THE GATHERING OF THE PEOPLE: In the traditional summer encampment pattern, the entire Confederacy moved to the Okan site — the ceremony was inseparable from the great summer gathering of all the bands.

THE SELECTION OF THE CENTER POLE: A specific cottonwood tree is selected — a tree with a naturally forked top. Its cutting and transport to the ceremony site involves specific sacred protocols. The tree's arrival at the ceremony site is the beginning of the Okan itself.

THE SWEAT LODGES: Multiple rounds of sweat lodge purification precede the main ceremony, preparing participants physically and spiritually.

The Sundance Ceremony — Day-by-Day Structure

DAY ONE — THE RAISING OF THE CENTER POLE: The most dramatic moment of the Okan — the center pole is raised and set into the prepared hole at the center of the dance arbor. Before raising, specific sacred objects (buffalo tongue, sacred medicines, and specific offerings) are placed at the base of the pole. The pole is raised using ropes, with specific prayers and songs accompanying each stage of the raising.

DAY TWO — THE OPENING OF THE NATOAS BUNDLE: The Natoas Bundle (the sacred bundle of the Okan) is formally opened by the sponsoring woman under the supervision of senior sacred practitioners who know the Bundle's specific protocols. The opening is itself a ceremony.

DAY THREE — THE DANCING BEGINS: The dancers — those fulfilling specific vows — begin dancing within the arbor, facing the center pole, moving toward it and back. Fasting and the specific physical demands of the dance are the expression of the vow's fulfillment.

DAY FOUR AND AFTER — CONTINUATION: The Okan continues for multiple days. The specific duration and the specific ceremonies vary by year and by the specific vows being fulfilled. The piercing ceremony — in which some male participants traditionally pierced their chest skin and attached themselves to the center pole by rawhide thongs — is the most extreme expression of the vow's fulfillment, and its continuation or revival in contemporary practice varies by community.

The Ikunuhkahtsi — Age-Graded Societies and Social Structure

The Ikunuhkahtsi (the All Comrades — sometimes rendered as the age-graded warrior societies) were the primary social organization of Blackfoot men — a system of ceremonial societies organized by age cohort, through which men progressed across their lifetime, purchasing membership in each society from the members of the preceding age group.

Each society had its own regalia, its own songs, its own dances, its own specific ceremonial functions, and its own specific role in the community's life. The youngest societies handled specific policing functions at the summer encampment; more senior societies held ceremonial authority; the most senior societies held the highest ceremonial and political standing.

War leadership operated on a separate, achievement-based track: the title of war chief could not be inherited or elected but had to be earned through specific documented acts of bravery, including touching a living enemy in combat. Peace chiefs were chosen by the people specifically to manage diplomacy and relations with other nations. This combination — inherited-by-cohort ceremonial societies layered over an achievement-based leadership system — produced one of the most sophisticated governance structures on the northern plains.

The Horn Society and Sacred Societies

The Horn Society (Piitaiks — 'Horn People') is the most sacred of the Blackfoot men's societies — the senior society whose members hold the highest ceremonial authority within the Ikunuhkahtsi system. The Horn Society presides over the Okan; its members are responsible for specific sacred functions during the Sundance and other major ceremonies.

The Motokiks (Women's Societies) are the corresponding sacred societies for women — the most important being the Motokiks Society itself, which has specific ceremonial functions within the Okan and whose members hold specific sacred authority. The Blackfoot tradition recognizes women's ceremonial authority explicitly; the Natoas Bundle (the central sacred object of the Okan) is held by a woman, and the Okan cannot be held without a woman's vow.

Names as Sacred Property — Birth and the Blackfoot Naming Tradition

Among the Blackfoot, a name is sacred property — it carries power, it belongs to specific individuals, and it can be transferred (with ceremony) from one person to another. A person may carry several names across their lifetime — a birth name, names earned through specific achievements, and names received through transfer.

The birth of a child is marked by specific ceremonies. A child's name is typically given by an elder or sacred practitioner with specific authority — the name is understood as a gift from the sacred world, not merely a label chosen by the parents. The name carries specific sacred power and specific sacred obligations.

The transfer of a name — particularly a prestigious name associated with a sacred being or a great ancestor — is a formal ceremony with its own protocols. The recipient of a transferred name receives not just the name but the sacred power and the sacred relationship that the name carries.

The Vision Quest — Going to Seek Power

The Vision Quest (sometimes called 'going to seek power' or 'fasting for a vision') is the individual spiritual practice through which a person seeks direct communication with the sacred beings of the above, below, and earth worlds, asking for guidance, for power, for a sacred ally, and for the specific knowledge that will define their sacred role in the community.

The vision quest is not a one-time adolescent rite in Blackfoot tradition — it is a practice that may be undertaken multiple times across a person's lifetime, at significant transition points, in response to crisis, or when seeking specific sacred guidance. Each vision quest is unique; the experiences and the sacred allies gained are specific to the individual.

The Vision Quest — Step-by-Step

STEP 1 — THE DECISION AND MENTOR: A person seeking a vision first approaches a senior sacred practitioner who has themselves received visions and who can guide the preparation.

STEP 2 — PURIFICATION (SWEAT LODGE): Before going to the vision quest site, the seeker undergoes one or more sweat lodge ceremonies — clearing the body and mind of ordinary contamination and opening the seeker to sacred communication.

STEP 3 — THE OFFERING PREPARATION: Specific offerings are prepared — particularly tobacco, which is the most universal sacred offering in the Blackfoot tradition, and sweetgrass and sage for purification.

STEP 4 — THE GOING OUT: The seeker goes to the specific sacred location identified by their mentor — often a hilltop or elevated place with clear sight lines to the sky. They go alone.

STEP 5 — THE FAST: The seeker fasts from food and water for the duration of the quest — typically four days and four nights, though the specific duration is set by the mentor. No shelter is used.

STEP 6 — THE VIGIL: The seeker maintains their vigil — praying, singing sacred songs, making offerings — waiting for the sacred being who will come.

STEP 7 — THE VISION: A sacred being appears — in the form of an animal, a sacred being from the Above or Below worlds, an ancestor, or in some other form. The being conveys specific knowledge, gives specific power, and establishes a specific ongoing relationship.

STEP 8 — THE RETURN AND TELLING: The seeker returns to their mentor and tells them what happened. The mentor helps interpret the vision and identify the obligations and gifts it carries.

Sweat Lodge (Motokiks) — The Foundational Purification Practice

The Sweat Lodge (Motokiks — the Blackfoot term) is the most regularly practiced and most broadly used purification ceremony in the Blackfoot tradition — used as preparation for virtually every other sacred practice (before the Okan, before the vision quest, before bundle ceremonies, before significant undertakings of any kind).

The sweat lodge is a small dome structure built from willow branches and covered with hides or blankets — large enough for a small group of participants to sit inside. A fire outside heats stones (the 'Grandfathers' — Pakipawa'taakii) to red heat, and the stones are brought inside and placed in a central pit. Water poured on the stones creates intense steam heat.

Sweat Lodge — Step-by-Step

STEP 1 — THE BUILDING: The sweat lodge is built from willow branches bent into a dome shape — a specific number of poles, oriented in a specific direction, with the door facing east.

STEP 2 — THE FIRE: The fire for heating the stones is built in a specific way — the stones arranged in the fire with specific protocols.

STEP 3 — THE PREPARATION: Participants prepare — smudging with sweetgrass or sage, removing metal objects (metal conducts heat), setting their intentions for the ceremony.

STEP 4 — THE ENTERING: Participants enter clockwise, moving to their positions. The leader goes in last and is closest to the door.

STEP 5 — THE OPENING PRAYERS: Specific opening prayers acknowledge the sacred beings, the four directions, and the specific purpose of this particular ceremony.

STEP 6 — THE GRANDFATHERS ARE BROUGHT IN: The red-hot stones are carried using deer antlers — never metal tools in traditional ceremony. Each stone is greeted as it enters; tobacco or cedar placed on it produces fragrant sacred smoke. The stones are arranged in the central pit.

STEP 7 — THE FOUR ROUNDS: The ceremony proceeds in four rounds corresponding to the four directions, door opened briefly between each. FIRST ROUND: Door closed. Water poured on stones creates steam. Prayers spoken in Blackfoot. SECOND ROUND: Continued prayers and songs. THIRD ROUND: Individual prayers and healing requests. FOURTH ROUND: Gratitude and closing prayers.

STEP 8 — THE EXIT AND PLUNGE: After each round, participants may exit for fresh air. After the ceremony, traditional practice included plunging into cold water — a river or stream — to complete the purification.

Iniskim — The Buffalo Calling Stone

The Iniskim (Buffalo Stone — also iniskim or iiniiskim) is one of the most distinctively Blackfoot of all sacred objects — a small naturally occurring fossil or oddly shaped stone that is understood as a gift from the Buffalo people, capable of calling Buffalo herds to the hunting area when used in proper ceremony.

THE ORIGIN STORY: A young woman, starving during a time of scarcity, heard a stone singing to her. She picked it up and it taught her the specific songs and ceremony for calling the Buffalo. She brought this knowledge back to her people,

and the Buffalo came. Every Iniskim carries this origin story — the stone is not merely an object but the specific gift of the Buffalo people to the Blackfoot.

Today, with the Buffalo no longer present on the plains in the way they once were, Iniskim are still held as sacred objects — the ceremonial relationship with the Buffalo spirit maintained even in physical absence, awaiting the Buffalo's return.

Sacred Herbs — Sweetgrass, Sage, and Cedar

SWEETGRASS (IIYAHKIOHKOTOKI — 'HOLY GRASS')

The most important and most widely used sacred plant — a slender, fragrant grass (*Hierochloa odorata*) that grows in moist areas of the northern plains and parkland. Sweetgrass is braided in three-strand braids for storage and ceremonial use. The three strands represent the mind, the body, and the spirit in some teachings. Sweetgrass smoke invites the sacred beings; it is burned at the beginning of ceremonies, used to purify sacred objects and participants, and offered as the most basic form of prayer.

SAGE

Sage (several species, including *Artemisia ludoviciana*) is used for purification in a different register than sweetgrass — where sweetgrass invites and welcomes, sage cleanses and protects. Sage is used to clear spaces of unwanted energies, to protect participants during ceremony, and to prepare the body for sacred work.

CEDAR

Cedar is used in purification ceremonies, particularly in conjunction with the sweat lodge. Cedar boughs placed on the floor of the sweat lodge provide fragrance and sacred presence; cedar smoke is used for specific purification purposes.

Death, Mourning, and the Journey to the Sand Hills

In Blackfoot sacred understanding, the spirit (*naato'si* — literally 'sun-like', the spirit dimension of the person) continues after the body's death. The dead travel to the Sand Hills (*Iksiskaaiksi*) — a spirit world in the south where the deceased live in a manner similar to earthly life, but without the hardships of cold, hunger, or conflict.

THE MOURNING PERIOD: Traditional mourning practices involved specific physical expressions — cutting the hair, wearing particular clothing, making specific offerings. The mourning period was understood as a time of specific sacred vulnerability, requiring specific care and specific ceremonial attention. Widows and widowers observed specific mourning protocols for defined periods.

SCAFFOLD BURIAL: Traditional Blackfoot burial practice placed the body on a scaffold above the ground, or on a high place, with the deceased's sacred possessions and horse. This practice honored the person's sacred property and provided for their needs in the Sand Hills. The grave was associated with the deceased's ongoing presence; specific protocols governed how and whether living people approached it.

BUNDLES AT DEATH: When a Bundle keeper died, the Bundle required careful ceremonial handling — it could not simply be left; it had to be properly transferred or properly retired. The death of a Bundle keeper was a sacred crisis requiring immediate ceremonial attention.

The Transfer Ceremony (*Isskinikssiyi*)

The Transfer Ceremony is the most important mechanism of sacred knowledge transmission in Blackfoot culture — the formal process through which a Medicine Bundle, with all its associated songs, prayers, and ceremonial knowledge, passes from one custodian to another. It is simultaneously a sacred ceremony in its own right, a legal transaction (in the Blackfoot sense of law), an educational event, and a community celebration.

THE PREPARATION PERIOD: A transfer does not happen spontaneously. The process begins when a person approaches a Bundle keeper and expresses their desire to receive the Bundle. Negotiations follow — the price of the transfer (which may include horses, blankets, money, or specific sacred items), the timing, and the specific arrangements.

THE GATHERING: The transfer ceremony requires the presence of the current keeper, the incoming keeper, their spouses, and community members who witness the transfer. The songs, prayers, and ceremonial content of the Bundle are sung and performed in full — the incoming keeper learning them through direct participation.

THE FORMAL TRANSFER: At the ceremony's culmination, the Bundle physically changes hands — the outgoing keeper formally releases their sacred relationship with it, and the incoming keeper formally accepts their new sacred obligation. From this moment, the Bundle's needs become the new keeper's responsibility.

Blackfoot Astronomy and the Sacred Calendar

The Blackfoot maintained a detailed knowledge of the night sky — star clusters, individual stars, and the movements of celestial bodies — integrated into their sacred tradition and their ceremonial calendar. The star cluster called *Ihkitsikammiksi* (the Lost Children, identified with the Pleiades) was particularly significant — its rising and setting marked specific ceremonial moments.

The annual ceremonial cycle was organized around the movements of the Buffalo and the cycles of the seasons: the winter dispersal of bands into sheltered river valleys, the spring gathering as the Buffalo moved onto the plains, the summer great camp and *Okan*, the fall hunt, and the return to winter quarters. Each phase of the cycle carried specific ceremonial obligations and specific ceremonial opportunities.

The Blackfoot Star Map — a painted star chart whose existence was documented in the early 20th century — encoded specific astronomical knowledge in a traditional medium, demonstrating the integration of celestial observation into the broader knowledge system of the Blackfoot tradition.

Contemporary Blackfoot — Repatriation and Living Tradition

The Blackfoot nations today are engaged in active cultural revitalization — language programs, ceremonial revival, and land rights advocacy. The Blackfoot language (*Niitsipii-tai'i*) is an endangered language; extensive immersion programs and documentation efforts are underway across the three Canadian nations and the Blackfeet Nation in Montana.

The *Okan* is still held every summer. Bundles are still transferred. The sacred societies maintain their ceremonial functions. The sweat lodge is still the foundational purification practice for all serious ceremony. The connection to the Buffalo — and the advocacy for Buffalo restoration to traditional Blackfoot territory — is a living part of contemporary Blackfoot cultural and political life. **IINNII INITIATIVE AND THE BUFFALO RETURN:** In 2009, leaders of all four Blackfoot Confederacy tribes launched the *Iinnii* Initiative, a cross-border effort to return free-roaming buffalo (*iinnii*) to their traditional homelands. The initiative combined Indigenous knowledge, ecological science, and government partnership. On June 26, 2023, the Blackfeet Nation released 49 wild bison near Chief Mountain (*Ninaiistako*, a sacred site), adjacent to Glacier National Park and the Canadian border. This event was described as the first time in American history that a Sovereign Indigenous Nation returned wild free-roaming buffalo to their native habitat. The release represents both ecological restoration and sacred covenant renewal: the return of the buffalo is understood as the renewal of the central sacred relationship that defines Blackfoot identity.

SEPTEMBER 2023 BADGER-TWO MEDICINE VICTORY: On September 1, 2023, the Blackfeet Nation achieved a landmark legal victory in a 40-year fight to protect the Badger-Two Medicine area from oil and gas development. The Badger-Two Medicine (*Miistakis*, the Backbone of the World) is a 130,000-acre sacred landscape adjacent to Glacier National Park that holds profound cultural and spiritual significance to the Blackfeet Nation, including creation stories and sacred sites used for prayer and healing. The Reagan administration had issued oil and gas leases in the area in the early 1980s; the Blackfeet and their allies fought for four decades to have them cancelled. In September 2023, Louisiana-based Solenex LLC, the last remaining leaseholder, agreed to permanently relinquish its lease in a settlement that ended all future drilling rights in the area. The entire Badger-Two Medicine is now permanently protected from mineral development. **OCTOBER 2025 BLACKFOOT LANGUAGE SYMPOSIUM:** In October 2025, the Kainai Blood Nation hosted its 14th annual Blackfoot Language Symposium in Lethbridge, Alberta, drawing approximately 300 attendees per day over three days. The symposium focused on language revitalization under the theme *Preparing Ourselves*. The Blackfoot language is a core pillar of cultural identity. The symposium series, now spanning 14 years, represents the sustained work of language preservation alongside the Blackfoot Digital Library and Piegan Institute immersion schools. **JUNE 2024 — EXETER REPATRIATION:** In June 2024, the Siksika Nation formally repatriated a sacred Buffalo Woman's Headdress — identified as a *Motokiks* ceremonial bird bundle — from the Royal Albert

Memorial Museum (RAMM) in Exeter, England. The bundle had been held by the museum since approximately 1920, acquired during the colonial era without the community's meaningful consent. The repatriation was the result of years of negotiation between the Siksika Nation and the museum, and was received by members of the Holy Buffalo Woman Society. It is one of the most significant sacred object repatriations in recent Blackfoot history. APRIL 2024 GENETIC STUDY: In April 2024, a study published in Science Advances, led by members of the Blackfoot Confederacy in partnership with researchers from multiple U.S. universities, confirmed that the Blackfoot have a distinct genetic lineage dating back approximately 18,000 years to the late Pleistocene. The study compared DNA from living Blackfoot community members with ancestral remains held at the Blackfeet Tribal Historic Preservation Office and the Smithsonian Institution. The findings revealed a previously unknown genomic lineage that diverged from all other North American Indigenous groups approximately 18,000 years ago, corroborating oral histories and archaeological records. The study was specifically designed to provide scientific evidence to support Blackfoot land and water treaty rights claims.

Blackfoot Sacred Wellness -- Nitsitapiisinni and the Medicine Bundle

Nitsitapiisinni (the Blackfoot way of life -- literally "the way of the real people") is the Blackfoot wellness framework: the understanding that physical health, spiritual balance, community harmony, and right relationship with the land and the sacred beings are not separate dimensions of wellbeing but expressions of the same underlying alignment. A person who is living in nitsitapiisinni is well in all four dimensions simultaneously. A person who is ill in any one dimension is out of alignment in all of them.

The Medicine Bundle is the primary sacred wellness technology in the Blackfoot tradition. Each bundle carries the accumulated sacred power of the beings and ceremonies associated with it -- the Beaver Bundle, the Natoas Bundle (Sun Dance bundle), the Iniskim (buffalo stone) bundles, and the many personal and clan bundles each carry specific protective and healing qualities. The bundle keeper's relationship with their bundle is itself a wellness practice: the specific protocols for feeding the bundle, for opening it at appropriate seasons, for conducting the specific ceremonies associated with it maintain the keeper in active sacred relationship that the tradition holds as foundational to health.

The sweat lodge (Iniskim) is the primary physical purification practice -- used before ceremonies, before significant undertakings, and as a regular maintenance practice. The sweat lodge prayer addresses Ih̓tsipatapiiyo'pa (the Great Source, the supreme sacred power) and the specific sacred beings associated with healing. The specific plants used in the lodge -- sweetgrass, sage, and specific medicinal plants gathered from the prairies and foothills of the Blackfoot territory -- are understood as medicine beings whose cooperation is requested through specific prayers before they are used.

The land itself is the most fundamental wellness resource in the Blackfoot tradition. Specific landscapes carry specific healing qualities: the springs and rivers carry the water-beings' medicine, specific mountains hold specific sacred powers available to those who approach them correctly, the prairie landscape as a whole is understood as a living medicine web that the people are embedded in rather than standing apart from. The disconnection of the Blackfoot people from their traditional territories through reservation boundaries, land alienation, and restrictions on traditional land use is understood not merely as a political and economic harm but as a specific disruption of the sacred wellness relationship between the people and the land they emerged from.

The Haligrity Lens — Bundle, Transfer, and Living Sacred Objects

The Blackfoot Confederacy's sacred tradition offers Haligrity several specific gifts of extraordinary relevance: the most complete available model of a living sacred object (the Medicine Bundle) as an active relationship rather than a possession; the Transfer Ceremony as the most complete available model of sacred knowledge transmission through direct ceremonial experience; and the vision quest as the most formally structured available model of individual direct encounter with the sacred world.

The Medicine Bundle breathes. It must be fed. It was given by a sacred being to a specific person in a specific moment of crisis or grace, and that moment lives inside the Bundle as its origin and its power. When the Bundle is transferred, the origin story is re-enacted — the power is renewed through the narrative, not merely symbolized by it. This is what Haligrity holds about sacred objects and sacred knowledge: they are alive, they require relationship, and they pass not by inheritance but by ceremony.

"The land is not ours. We belong to the land. The Buffalo chose us. We did not choose the Buffalo. The Sun did not make a covenant with our chiefs. He made it with all of us — the living, the dead, and those not yet born."

— Reflecting the teaching of Blackfoot elders

Napi walked north and has not come back. The center pole rises in the Okan Lodge and the Sun looks down. The Bundle breathes in its wrappings. The Grandfather stones glow red in the sweat lodge fire. The Iniskim sings to the woman who is willing to listen. The Blackfoot Confederacy is still here. Grand Rising.